over 2,300 candidates had filled to run from approximately 480 parties. SLORC made it clear that it would remain in power in the postelection transition period while a new constitution was drafted.

There was still a sense of uncertainty regarding whether the 1947 or 1974 constitution was legitimate. It seemed that SLORC assumed that power would be transferred to the Pyithu Hluttaw (people's assembly) at the appropriate time. The assembly was considered to be the most significant branch of government. A troubling concern was over the meaning of the election process. The junta believed that the purpose of the process was to strengthen the regime, while the opposition believed the election to be an exercise in popular sovereignty. This debate over the true meaning of the process haunted modern Burma for the foreseeable future.

The NLD was the most significant opposition movement in Burma. Factionalism would damage the party in late 1988, as Aung Gyi decided to abandon the movement. The retired general claimed that communists had infiltrated the NLD. The NLD had adapted the fighting peacock as the symbol of the movement, something that the early student movement had used as a symbol. The electoral commission forbid the use of religious symbols as well as animals for party logos, so the NLD selected the bamboo peasant hat to represent the people of Burma.

In December 1988, Aung San Suu Kyi's mother passed away. Over 100,000 citizens, including key members of SLORC and a large contingent of foreign ambassadors, attended her state funeral. Suu Kyi embarked on a massive tour across the nation in 1989. She spoke on the theme of national unity in the ethnically diverse regions of the countries. The regime's tactics against her included harassment, intimidation, and the false imprisonment of NLD members. On an ominous day in April, several members of a military contingency drew their rifles on Suu Kyi. A last-minute order to desist by a captain probably saved her life. This highlighted the potential problem of safety on the campaign trail. Suu Kyi continued to stress nonviolence to her followers. As anniversaries of the key dates from the “year of rage” approached, tensions increased. The military prepared for potential confrontations by literally changing the physical landscape of key areas. Trees were cut down, walls were built, and the relocation of urban resistances was undertaken. Up to 500,000 residents would be impacted by SLORC's relocation policies.